



THIS ENTERPRISE WILL RETURN IMMENSE REWARDS

THE CONSTRUCTION OF THE SUEZ CANAL
(1859–1869)

IN CONTEXT

FOCUS

Imperial economies

BEFORE

1838 The first Atlantic crossing under steam power alone is made.

1858 The first transatlantic telegraph cable is laid.

AFTER

1869 The Suez Canal opens, slashing sailing times between Europe and the East.

1878 The Gold Standard is adopted in Europe; the US follows suit in 1900.

1891 The Trans-Siberian railroad is begun. It is completed in 1905.

1899–1902 Britain aims to secure control of South Africa in the Second Boer War.

1914 The Panama Canal, linking the Atlantic and Pacific oceans, opens.

The ceremonial opening, on November 17, 1869, of the Suez Canal, linking the Mediterranean and the Red seas, was an emphatic declaration of European—specifically, French—technological and financial means. It was also a significant illustration of a rapidly emerging and increasingly interdependent global economy, featuring goods from all parts of the world being

The **Industrial Revolution** allows the **rapid development** of Western economies.

New industries are hungry for **more resources**.

New classes of workers hanker for **consumer goods**.

Developed countries **build empires** and use their **colonial muscle** to feed their industries.

Technology and transport develop to support this new global economy.

The Suez Canal is constructed, facilitating global trade by shortening shipping routes substantially.

traded on an ever-larger scale. This was a process dominated by Europe's colonial powers and the United States, overwhelmingly its principal beneficiaries. It was simultaneously a further boost to Europe's imperial ambitions.

The Suez Canal reduced the route between London and Mumbai (Bombay) by 41 percent, and the route between London